

# THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1986-10-12

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

1 dear b ahá'í f riends,

**The above statement which was sent to you with our covering letter of**

21 february 1986 has been revised by the office of public information and

22 of justice, we enclose a copy of the revised statement, which supersedes the

23 previous one.

24 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

**Department of tHe secretariat**

## **Apartheid: A Bahá'í View**

25 A little more than a hundred years ago, bahá'u'lláh, founder of the bahá'í

26 faith, declared that mankind was entering upon a new era in its history

27 when accelerating processes of unification would soon compel universal rec-ognition  
that humanity is one single race, one distinct species. he appealed 5.1

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8 to the peoples of the world to accept this central truth and to set aside the

9 barriers of race, nationality, and culture which have been principal causes

10 of war throughout history. There is, he said, no possibility of achievement

11 of world peace until the fundamental principle of unity has been accepted

12 and given practical effect in the organization of society.

13 consequently, from the time of its inception more than a century ago,

14 the bahá'í world community has been characterized by the integration of

15 the many religious, racial, ethnic, cultural, linguistic and national elements which it  
comprises. marriage between persons of different ethnic, and

16 cultural backgrounds, and particularly between black and white bahá'ís,

17 is warmly encouraged in the bahá'í scriptures. in order to make certain  
 18 that those members who suffer discrimination in society as a whole are not prevented  
 from full participation in the life of the community, the bahá'í  
 19 teachings contain certain administrative principles which are designed to overcome  
 the handicaps created by social inequalities. for example, where a  
 20 tie vote has been cast in a bahá'í community election or where two or more  
 21 believers are equally qualified for a particular office, priority is given as a  
 22 matter of principle to the one representing the disadvantaged or oppressed  
 23 sector of society.  
 24 it is these principles which have guided the bahá'ís in South Africa since  
 25 the opening years of this century. when the apartheid laws made it illegal  
 26 for certain local groups, including elected bahá'í Spiritual Assemblies, to  
 27 contain members from different racial backgrounds, it was the white bahá'ís  
 28 who surrendered the privilege of elected membership so that the principle  
 29 of giving priority to disadvantaged segments of society could continue to  
 30 prevail. except for these local decision-making bodies whose membership  
 31 was explicitly limited by civil law, bahá'í meetings in South Africa have been  
 32 racially integrated, a fact well known to the civil authorities.  
 33 beyond attempting to provide an encouraging example of racial integra-  
 34 tion, the bahá'í community in South Africa has devoted much of its energy  
 35 to the inculcation of bahá'í principles related to the oneness of mankind  
 36 and on the development of a sense of self-worth and of social responsibility  
 37 in the individual. parallel with these activities has been a program aimed  
 38 at training Spiritual Assemblies in principles of consultation and problem-  
 39 solving. bahá'ís are particularly proud of the results of this effort because  
 40 through it black believers have assumed the highest elective and appointive offices in  
 the community.<sup>6.3</sup>

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7 1986–1992 • The Six Year Plan

8 9This historical background points up the bahá'í conviction that solutions  
 9 to situations such as that which prevails in South Africa must draw on the

10 force of example. fundamental changes in social attitude will be most read-  
 11 ily achieved if the relevant spiritual and moral principles are courageously  
 12 set forth and if men and women of good will can see others attempting successfully  
 to give these ideals practical expression in individual and com-  
 13 munity life.  
 14 violating as it does the very honor of humanity, the system of apartheid  
 15 arouses in peoples of all nations and cultures deep feelings of abhorrence.  
 16 bahá'ís share these feelings particularly keenly. The moral challenge which  
 17 the situation represents, however, has now become intertwined with parti-san  
 political concerns. So complete is this interrelationship that the issues in the conflict are  
 inextricable from one another: social protest originating in  
 18 moral outrage has assumed the character of political action.  
 19 it is natural that it should do so, given the adversary principle that char-  
 20 acterizes our political traditions throughout the world. but political action,  
 21 in the absence of conditions for genuine consultation, in which partisan interests are  
 subordinated to the interests of the whole, will not itself bring  
 22 an enduring resolution of problems as serious as those convulsing South Africa.  
 however difficult the task and however disheartening the present  
 23 situation may seem, segments of South African society who believe full  
 24 integration to be the fundamental issue face the challenge of focusing their  
 25 efforts on creating such conditions. This is a moral imperative as urgent as any other  
 motivating peoples of good will who seek to free South Africa  
 26 from its terrible burden.  
 27 bahá'ís are required by the teachings of their faith to refrain from in-  
 28 volvement in partisan political activity and civil disorder. This is true  
 29 whether such activity is a response to racial oppression, as is generally the  
 30 case in South Africa, or to more widespread attempts to keep people divided  
 31 and vulnerable such as the persecution of religious belief, the suppression of women,  
 or the denial of political freedom. The hard-won experience of bahá'ís under all these  
 conditions convinces them beyond any doubt that  
 32 humanity can learn to live as one family and that all the forces of contempo-rary  
 history are rapidly impelling the race in this direction. The pressure of these forces is  
 inescapable; eventually even South Africa will respond. The  
 33 quality of that response, and its speed, will depend as much on spiritual and

**moral conditions as it will on economic and political ones.6.6**

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**Equality of Women and Men**

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]